

Stippling

Building form and texture with dots

Stippling is the technique of creating images using only dots. It's slow, meditative, and produces uniquely beautiful results. Understanding stippling deepens your understanding of value and texture in all mediums.

KEY CONCEPTS

The Basic Principle

Stippling builds value through dot density. More dots per unit area = darker. Fewer dots = lighter. The eye perceives the average density as a value tone. There are no lines — only points.

Dot Size & Shape

Consistent dot size produces even, clean results. Varying dot size adds texture and energy. Dots should be round, not slashes or commas — hold the pen perpendicular to the paper and touch, don't drag.

Building Value

Start sparse. Add dots in the darker areas. Add more passes until the desired density is reached. It's much easier to add more dots than to remove them — work light to dark, methodically.

Stippling for Texture

Varying the irregularity and size of dots creates different surface textures. Dense, even stippling reads as smooth. Clustered irregular stippling reads as rough. Sparse stippling suggests reflective or shiny surfaces.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Stipple a 5-step value scale using only dots. Take as long as needed.
2. Stipple a sphere completely — from white highlight to dark cast shadow.
3. Stipple a portrait or animal face using 3 values. No lines allowed.

FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Stippling Techniques

<https://youtu.be/OcJPNMFFKHs>

■ YouTube – Stippling Tutorial

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jbNNuqrZhyc>